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Review of *Mind* by Eric Matthews

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(Key Concepts in Philosophy) Continuum, 2005. viii + 146 pp.

Eric Matthews's *Mind: Key Concepts in Philosophy* is billed on the back cover as a comprehensive, clear, and authoritative guide to the philosophy of mind, suitable for those encountering the discipline for the first time. It also has a strong argumentative thread, mounting a sustained case for a form of non-reductive materialism, derived from Ryle, Wittgenstein, and Merleau-Ponty.

The book is in six chapters. The first two introduce and assess some of the major accounts of the mind in Western philosophy, focusing on substance dualism and what Matthews calls 'classical materialism'. Matthews discusses Aristotle's view of the mind, Cartesian dualism, type identity theory, eliminativism, and, briefly, functionalism. Having dealt with these positions, Matthews uses the next chapter to set out the view he favours, which is rooted in ordinary language philosophy and the phenomenological tradition. He introduces the concepts of subjectivity and intentionality, stressing the difficulties these features of the mind pose for reductive materialism, then goes on to give a sympathetic account of Ryle's nonreductive behaviourism and of Merleau-Ponty's view of the mind as an embodied subjectivity. The moral is that we should focus 'not on "minds", but on the beings who have minds and the role which having a mind plays in their lives' (p. 69).

The remaining chapters, which look at some philosophical problems relating to the mind, recapitulate the dialectic of the earlier chapters. The inadequacies of dualism and classical materialism are highlighted, and a form of non-reductive behaviourism recommended in their place. Chapter 4 asks whether animals and machines can be said to have minds. Matthews considers and rejects Descartes's arguments against the existence of animal mentality, but also takes a swipe at evolutionary psychology, which, he argues, ignores the role of personal and cultural factors in the explanation of action. Moving on to machine intelligence, Matthews outlines Searle's critique of Strong AI, buttressing it with considerations drawn from the private language argument. Machines are incapable of semantics, he maintains, because they do not participate in a society and have no purposes of their own; again, we need to think of mentality as essentially embodied. Chapter

5 looks at the problem of other minds. Matthews shows why it is particularly troubling for dualists, before appealing to Wittgenstein and Merleau-Ponty for a solution. Turning to the question of how we work out what others think or feel, Matthews argues against the 'theory-theory' view, on which the process is akin to scientific theorizing, and suggests that it requires creative interpretation, responsive to an open-ended set of criteria. The final chapter, 'Reasons and causes', draws together the threads of the book. Matthews argues that humans cannot be seen merely as biological mechanisms operating in accordance with causal laws, and maintains that we must recognize the distinctness and ineliminability of reason-based explanations of human action—though he insists that this need not involve a return to a dualism of substances. What it means to have a mind, he concludes, is 'to be an embodied subject: a human being, or similar creature, who is a biological organism, but who also responds to his or her environment subjectively and intentionally' (p. 137).

This book has many virtues. Matthews is a clear writer, and he explains philosophical positions well, setting them in their historical context. His presentation of arguments and objections is often brief (inevitable in a short volume of this kind), but it is always clear and level-headed. In arguing for his own views, Matthews illustrates how philosophical debate is conducted and makes a good case for an important position. However, as the preceding summary makes clear, it is somewhat misleading to describe this book as comprehensive and authoritative. It is, in fact, a selective and highly partisan work, which some philosophers will regard as old-fashioned. His adherence to a non-reductionist position leads Matthews to ignore the considerable body of work produced over the last thirty years or so by those seeking to integrate folk psychology with science and to formulate reductive explanations (if not type reductions) of mental phenomena. Consequently, many topics that are now seen as central to the discipline—functionalism, the representational theory of mind, computationalism, theories of content, connectionism, the hard problem of consciousness—are either omitted by Matthews or dealt with perfunctorily. (Functionalism is treated as a response to eliminativism and gets just four pages.) Of course, from Matthews's point of view much of this work is misguided and can be written off *a priori*. But this just emphasizes the need for a less partisan approach if one is to get a full idea of what is happening in the subject today. This is, then, a good but partial work. If a person were to read just one introduction to philosophy of mind, then I don't think it should be this

one; but if they were to read two or three, then this should definitely be among them.